Lesson 34 material: Project: Tell an Anecdote or a Personal Story

4.6: Unit Project Option 1- Tell an Anecdote

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Anecdotes

Note to the Teacher

Learning about anecdotes can be a good way to challenge a stronger group of students. For students who need more support, it may be best to skip the lesson on anecdotes and focus on Unit Project Option 2: Tell a Personal Story.

Learn about Anecdotes

An anecdote is a short amusing or interesting story. Usually something surprising or unexpected happens, and often the speaker has learned something from the story.

Pair Work

Look at the transcript of the story told by Sir Ken Robinson (15:19-17:29). What is the main idea or most important information given in each paragraph? Make notes next to each paragraph then share your ideas with the class.
https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity/transcript

Rules to Remember

Anecdotes usually have four parts:

- **Background information:** Who? When? Where? (description of setting and people)
- **The set-up:** The problem is introduced and sometimes a possible solution is presented.
- **The surprise:** Something surprising or unexpected happens.
- **Lesson or moral:** The story is resolved and we usually learn something important from it.

Practice

Complete the table below with information from Sir Ken Robinson's anecdote.

1. What was the surprise in the story?
2. What can we learn from the story?

Part of the Anecdote	Summarize each section of the anecdote in your own words.
Background Information	Gillian's school told her mother than Gillian had a learning disorder.
The Set-Up	Gillian's mother took her to a special doctor. The doctor listened to the problem. Then he turned on some music and asked Gillian's mom to leave the room with him. They left Gillian alone in the room with the music.
The Surprise	
The Lesson	

Task: Tell an Anecdote

1. Tell a short story about a memorable experience in which you or someone you know learned something. Memorize your story and make a video of yourself talking about your experience.
2. Use some of the -ed verbs you learned in this unit. Check that you have used the past tense correctly.
3. Include a transcript in which you identify -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups. Draw a / between thought groups and remember to pause between thought groups when you're telling your story.
4. Include a visual that will help us better understand your story. You can use a PowerPoint or a picture. Include your visual in your video.
5. Your speech must be 2-3 minutes long.

Purpose: Why are we doing this?

- You will practice speech giving skills including volume, eye contact, organization and telling an interesting story.

- You will review and practice using pronunciation features we have learned in class including -Ed endings, thought groups, and connected speech.

Rubric

60 points possible

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Needs Improvement (Resubmission Required)	No Marks (Resubmission Required)			
10	7	5	0				
Content	Tell a story about a memorable experience.	Say what you learned from the story.	Your story should include the four parts of an anecdote: background info, set-up, surprise, lesson.	The student tells a story about a memorable experience from which he/she learned something. All four parts of an anecdote are included.	The student tells a story about a memorable experience but only three parts of the anecdote are included.	The student tells a story about a memorable experience but doesn't only two parts of the anecdote are included.	The story is too short. Not enough information is provided.
Speech organization and clarity (interesting, clear explanation)	The speech is well organized. The presentation is interesting and a clear explanation is given.	There are some errors in grammar, sentence structure and/or vocabulary that can occasionally cause confusion for the listener, but most of the presentation is clear.	There are some errors in grammar, sentence structure and/or vocabulary that can occasionally cause confusion for the listener, but most of the presentation is clear.	The presentation is poorly organized and difficult ot follow.			
Delivery (volume, eye contact)	The student speaks loudly enough to be understood comfortably and the student looks directly at the camera. The student has memorized most of the presentation and speaks confidently with little aid from notes.	The student looks at the video occasionally. The student is reading some of the presetation and has made some attempt to practice or memorize the presentation before reading.	The student is reading most of the presentation and has made little effort to practice or memorize the presentation before recording. The student is too reliant on notes.	The student's face is not seen during the video at any time and/or the student reads the entire presentation, providing little evidence that he/she understands what is being read.			
Pronunciation	-Ed Endings	Connected Speech	Thought Groups	The student is very clear and easy to understand. Student successfully uses most -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups.	The student is mostly clear and easy to understand. The student uses two of the three pronunciation features successfully.	The student is understandable some of the time. The student uses one of the pronunciation features successfully.	Most of the presentation is difficult to understand. The student makes little effort to use -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups effectively.

Visual (helps the presentation)	Student provides a picture that helps the presentation.	No visual is provided or the image is not relevant to the story.		
Transcript	Transcript is provided. All -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is provided. Most -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is provided. A few -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is not provided OR no -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.
Total				

Brainstorm

Complete the table with ideas for your story. You do not need to write complete sentences.

Questions	Your Notes	
What happened?	Who was involved?	When and where did the story happen?
What was the problem?		
What was surprising?		
What did you learn from this experience?		

Write

Write a rough draft of your anecdote here. Remember to include all four parts of an anecdote. When you're finished, give your rough draft to your teacher for feedback.

Post-Project Discussion

Your classmates videos will be posted on an online forum. Watch two of your classmates' videos. Post a thoughtful comment or question to each classmate.

Links on the original page

- TED talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity/transcript

4.7: Unit Project Option 2- Tell a Personal Story

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/04%3A_Education_and_Creativity/4.07%3A_Unit_Project_Option_2-_Tell_a_Personal_Story
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Task: Tell a Personal Story

1. Talk about a memorable experience you've had. Memorize your story and make a video of yourself talking about your experience.
2. Answer the following questions:
   - What happened?
   - Who was involved?
   - When and where did the story happen?
   - Why was the experience memorable?
3. Use some of the -ed verbs you learned in this unit. Check that you have used the past tense correctly.
4. Include a transcript in which you identify -ed endings and connected speech. Draw a / between thought groups and remember to pause.
5. Include a visual that will help us better understand your story. You can use a PowerPoint or a picture. Include your visual in your video.
6. Your speech must be 2-3 minutes.

Purpose: Why are we doing this?

- You will practice speech giving skills included volume, eye contact, organization and telling an interesting story.
- You will review and practice using pronunciation features we have learned in class including -Ed endings, thought groups, and connected speech.

Rubric

60 points possible

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Needs Improvement (Resubmission Required)	No Marks (Resubmission Required)		
10	7	5	0			
Content	Tell a story about a memorable experience.	Your story should include answers to the following questions: Who? What? When? Where? Why? (see task instructions)	The student tells a story about a memorable experience. All five questions are answered in the presentation.	The student tells a story about a memorable experience. Four of the questions have been answered.	The student tells a story about a memorable experience. Three questions have been answered.	The story is too short. Not enough information is provided. Two or fewer questions have been answered.
Speech organization and clarity (interesting, clear explanation)	The speech is well organized. The presentation is interesting and a clear explanation is given.	There are some errors in grammar, sentence structure and/or vocabulary that can occasionally cause confusion for the listener, but most of the presentation is clear.	There are some errors in grammar, sentence structure and/or vocabulary that can occasionally cause confusion for the listener, but most of the presentation is clear.	The presentation is poorly organized and difficult ot follow.		

Delivery (volume, eye contact)	The student speaks loudly enough to be understood comfortably and the student looks directly at the camera. The student has memorized most of the presentation and speaks confidently with little aid from notes.	The student looks at the video occasionally. The student is reading some of the presetation and has made some attempt to practice or memorize the presentation before reading.	The student is reading most of the presentation and has made little effort to practice or memorize the presentation before recording. The student is too reliant on notes.	The student's face is not seen during the video at any time and/or the student reads the entire presentation, providing little evidence that he/she understands what is being read.			
Pronunciation	-Ed Endings	Connected Speech	Thought Groups	The student is very clear and easy to understand. Student successfully uses most -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups.	The student is mostly clear and easy to understand. The student uses two of the three pronunciation features successfully.	The student is understandable some of the time. The student uses one of the pronunciation features successfully.	Most of the presentation is difficult to understand. The student makes little effort to use -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups effectively.
Visual (helps the presentation)	Student provides a picture that helps the presentation.	No visual is provided or the image is not relevant to the story.					
Transcript	Transcript is provided. All -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is provided. Most -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is provided. A few -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.	Transcript is not provided OR no -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups are correctly identified.			
Total							

Example

Look at the teacher's example. Work with a partner to identify -ed endings, connected speech, and thought groups. The first few pronunciation features have been identified for you as an example.

Transcript

I was hir**ed** to teach English /at a school in Thailand /from 2008-2009. /While I was there, /I travel**ed** a lot. / I went to many beaches /and beautiful places. /I swam in rivers /with waterfalls.

One of my most memorable experiences in Thailand was when I went to Kanchanaburi and I visited the Tiger Temple. The Tiger Temple is a place where monks have taken in tigers to protect them from poachers. I went to the Tiger Temple with a friend. We ate breakfast together, and then they brought out the baby tigers. We played with the baby tigers and gave them bottles of milk. I also gave some milk to the bigger tigers.

Then we played with the tigers in the water, and we gave them baths. We also took one of the tigers for a walk. Finally we watched the big tigers play, and we took pictures with them. This was a memorable experience because I had the opportunity to spend time with real tigers.

I spent a year teaching English in Thailand, and it was during my experience there that I realized I wanted to be an ESL teacher. After that, I decided to get my Master in TESOL, so that I could teach ESL at colleges and universities.

Brainstorm

Complete the table with ideas for your story. You do not need to write complete sentences.

Questions	Your Notes
What happened?	
Who was involved?	When and where did the story happen?
Was there a problem?	Did anything surprising happen?
Why was the experience memorable?	Did you learn anything from the experience?

Write

Write a rough draft of your story here. Remember to include all four parts of an anecdote. When you're finished, give your rough draft to your teacher for feedback.

Post-Project Discussion

Your classmates videos will be posted on an online forum. Watch tow of your classmates' videos. Post a thoughtful comment or question to each classmate.